



Armed workers and soldiers taking part in the overthrow of Russia's Provisional Government by the Bolsheviks in Petrograd. They established a communist revolutionary regime.

ON JANUARY 9, GERMAN KAISER **WILHELM II (1859–1941)** approved the decision of his military commanders to engage in **unlimited submarine warfare**. The Germans knew that this would mean sinking American merchant vessels and would probably bring the neutral US into the war, but they believed they could sink enough ships to force Britain to sue for peace and make US intervention ineffectual. When an American cargo ship, the *Housatonic*, was sunk by a U-boat on February 3 off the Scilly Isles, the US broke off diplomatic relations with Germany.

Anticipating US entry into the war, German foreign minister Arthur Zimmermann decided to offer Mexico an alliance, encouraging it to fight to regain Texas, New Mexico, and Arizona from the US. A **telegram from Zimmerman** detailing



this plan was intercepted, decoded by British intelligence, and passed to the US government. When it was published in the US press it caused a sensation, stoking anti-German feeling already ignited by the U-boat campaign.

Propaganda poster

New York's Mayor's Committee on National Defense declared April 19 "Wake Up America Day," and publicized it with this poster.

On April 2, US president Woodrow Wilson (1856–1924) asked Congress to vote for a war "to make the world safe for democracy." Four days later, the **US declared war on Germany**, keeping independence of action by not formally allying itself with Britain and France. The slow process of building and equipping a mass conscript army began.

While the US was entering the war, Russia was caught up in revolutionary turmoil. A momentous sequence of events was triggered by food riots, strikes, and a mutiny of soldiers in Petrograd (St. Petersburg). On March 15, **Czar Nicholas II (1868–1918) abdicated** and a Provisional Government was established by politicians from the Duma (Russian parliament). Committees set up by workers and soldiers, known as "soviets," created a competing focus of political power. On April 16, **Vladimir Ilyich Lenin** (see panel, left), leader of the extremist Bolshevik Party, returned to Petrograd from exile in Switzerland. Lenin sought to radicalize the revolution by proposing an end to the war and "all power to the soviets."

The dominant personality in the Provisional Government, moderate socialist **Alexander Kerensky** (1881–1970), was

committed to continuing the war. The failure of the campaign he launched on July 1, known as the **Kerensky Offensive**, was followed by widespread mutinies in the army at the front and desertion. Attempts to suppress the Bolsheviks failed. The Provisional Government survived a coup attempt, but on November 7 it succumbed to an armed takeover organized by Lenin's associate, **Leon Trotsky** (1879–1940). Lenin set up a **revolutionary government** of People's Commissars and proclaimed a unilateral armistice.

Meanwhile, on the Western front stalemate and slaughter

continued. At the start of the year newly appointed French commander-in-chief Robert Nivelle (1856–1924) promised a crushing onslaught that would win the war in days. When the **Nivelle Offensive** was launched in mid-April, however, it proved no more successful than previous offensives. The disappointment was bitter. There were widespread mutinies and the French army threatened to disintegrate. Hastily appointed to replace Nivelle, General Philippe Pétain (1856–1951) restored order with a mixture of concessions and punishments, and ruled out any further French offensives.



VLADIMIR ILYICH LENIN (1870–1924)

Born into Russian minor gentry, Vladimir Ilyich Ulyanov became a Marxist activist, adopting the name "Lenin." Living in exile in Western Europe, he led the Bolsheviks from 1903. Returning to Russia in 1917, he was determined to radicalize the revolution through a Bolshevik seizure of power. Once in control, he ruthlessly stamped out all opposition, and founded the world's first communist state.



January 22 Addressing Senate, US president Wilson calls for "peace without victory"

February 1 Germany resumes unrestricted submarine warfare

February 21 German troops in France stage tactical withdrawal to Hindenburg Line

March 1 Zimmerman telegram, making clear German attempt to form alliance with Mexico, published in US

March 2 Strikes in Petrograd mark start of Russia's "February Revolution"

March 2 Jones Rice an American territory

March 8 US declares war on Germany

March 15 Czar Nicholas II abdicates, Provisional Government takes power in Russia

April 2 US declares war on Germany

April 6 US declares war on Germany

April 9 Canadian troops capture Vimy Ridge, France, in Arras offensive

April 16 Bolshevik leader Lenin arrives in Petrograd from Switzerland

April 16 French army launches Nivelle offensive

May 15 Pétain replaces Nivelle as commander-in-chief after mutinies in French army

May 18 Selective Service Act introduces conscription in US

June 7 Massive British mines destroy German trenches at Messines Ridge

June 13 Daylight raid on London by German Gotha bombers kills 162 people

June 16 First All-Russian Congress of Soviets meets in Petrograd

June 25 First troops of American Expeditionary Force arrive in France

June 29 Greece declares war on Central Powers